

3.1 Unit description

Overview

The use and management of resources is a key issue for geography and today's world. Consumption patterns highlight stark inequalities between regions, countries and groups of people. Many resources are finite, and rising consumption means that difficult decisions over the use of resources will have to be taken more frequently.

The planet is 'contested' in a variety of ways, for example:

- countries and groups are demanding access to a diminishing resource base (for instance fossil fuels, freshwater supplies and timber)
- groups are conflicting over the use of resources and their protection – the conservation versus development debate
- there are questions of economic development and inequality – should wealth creation or wealth redistribution be the primary goal?
- there is debate over the management of resources – should the aim be to make current patterns of consumption more sustainable, or are more radical actions needed?
- the question of whether technological development is the solution to problems of resource depletion and environmental degradation, or is it part of the problem?